

The oddly matched pair exchanged cordialities, but when they turned to business, the terms that Grant offered proved more generous than Lee had expected. Confederate officers and men must give their word not to take up arms again against the U.S. government and deliver up their weapons and other supplies as captured property. Officers would be permitted to keep their sidearms, horses, and personal baggage. All men would be free to return to their homes, “not to be disturbed by United States authority so long as they observe their paroles and the laws in force where they may reside.” This last phrase meant that the defeated soldiers were freed from the threat of further punishment or of prosecution for treason. In addition, Grant agreed to Lee’s request that common soldiers, too, should be allowed to keep their horses or mules for use as farm animals.

The formal act of surrender took place three days later. A line of Confederate soldiers tramped between columns of Union troops commanded by Major General Chamberlain to lay down their arms and battle standards. In exchange, they received written passes assuring them of a safe passage homeward. Lee himself headed back to Richmond, a commander without an army; as a mark of respect, a troupe of Union cavalry accompanied him for part of the way.